



ASUS P5Q Deluxe

P45 Arrives But Is It Same Story As The X48?

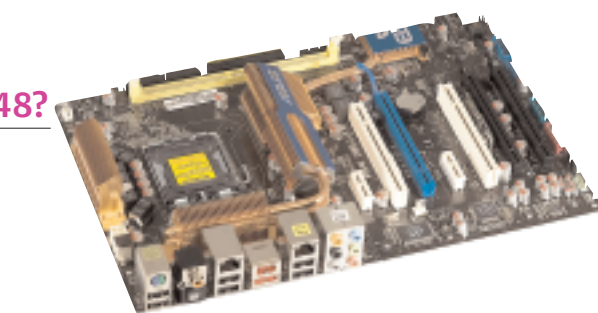
The Digit Test Centre received ASUS' latest offering—the P5Q Deluxe motherboard based on Intel's all new P45 chipset. The boards run on the P45 chip coupled with the new ICH10R, which is a step up from the ICH9R from the P35. One of the changes is that the P45 has a 1600 MHz bus speed as compared to 1333 MHz on the P35.

The motherboard has a really clean layout and there is the usual profusion of heatsinks and copper heat pipes running across the board. Overclocking features as usual are built in well like the other ASUS boards we've seen. BIOS settings can be saved and loaded as you wish.

We ran the same bar-

rage of tests and observed small jumps in performance in benchmarks such as PC Mark 2005 where it scored 2 to 3 per cent more than the P35's from our motherboard comparison test. 3DMark 2005 scores were also marginally higher than the P35. Small changes were noted in *Doom 3* running at low resolutions too.

Although performance doesn't seem to be the new P45's forte, ASUS has added some unique features to their board. One of them is called Express Gate—an operating system built into the motherboard that works without the need of an attached hard drive. The environment has Skype, Pidgin—an instant messenger—and a modified version of Firefox running on a cus-



tomised Linux distribution called Splashtop. Should you lose your operating system in a data crash, Express Gate will give you complete access to the Internet. There are features for copying data from hard drives as well as USB drives.

The new P45 chipset doesn't really do a whole lot more for performance. There is a marginal jump, but nothing substantial that would convince anyone to move from a P35 based board to a P45 one, for example. People who want to buy an enthusiast level board should consider the P45, but those who are already

on P35 and X38s will just have to wait.

Specifications:

LGA775 socket, System bus: 800 / 1066 / 1333 / 1600 MHz, Maximum RAM supported: 16 GB DDR2, ATI CrossFireX support, ATX form factor.
Contact: ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd.
Phone: 1-800-2090365
E-mail: media_india@asus.com
Web site: www.asus.in
Price: Rs 12,100

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

BenQ X2200W

Perfect For A Gaming Console!

The 22-inch BenQ X2200W is a LCD monitor targeted at gamers and movie enthusiasts—the styling on this screen is clearly indicative of that. The screen and the body both have a matte finish.

The screen has a medium-sized bezel all through but it is fatter on the sides, thin on the top and thick at the bottom. There are no buttons at the bottom of the screen but there is a metallic

looking dotted pattern which gives the screen a fine look. When the monitor is in idle mode, a blue light is emitted from the gap below which adds to its style. All these cosmetics make the screen look really chunky and huge.

The contrast ratio is good and the darks appear a little darker than most screens. The viewing angles are good too, as long as you are at the same level as the

screen. When you move up and down, things go horribly wrong—the display quality is pretty bad when you look at the monitor from the top or the bottom.

One of the biggest plus points is HDMI con-



nectivity, which is very rare in 22-inch screens—or any other screen for that matter. HDMI means that this monitor can be used as a display for your gaming consoles or HD players. There is a headphone jack for audio output as well.

There is no doubt that this is better than most of the screens in the market today, but those screens are priced very competitively. The X2200W isn't available right now, and

is expected in the next few months at a price of Rs 16,500, which is asking for quite a bit. At this price, one enters the entry level 24-inch LCD price bracket. If you want a cheap LCD screen for

the computer that doubles as your display for your consoles, then this might just be the one for you.

Specifications

Resolution: 1680x1050,

Contrast Ratio 1000:1, Maximum power consumption: 45 W, Response time: 5 ms.

Contact: Neoteric

Phone: 1-800-22-0808

E-mail: sales.enquiryin@BenQ.com

Web site: www.benq.com
Price: Rs 16,500

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Nikon D60

An Inch Up

The Nikon D60 is a compact 10.2 MP D-SLR, but also much larger than the typical point-and-shoot cameras. Unlike some of the higher-end D-SLRs, it isn't heavy at all. The kit comes with an 18-55 mm VR zoom lens, which is more or less the equivalent of a 3x optical zoom lens on a point-and-shoot camera. The camera performs flawlessly—switching between menus is quick and prompt. Firing the trigger immediately clicks a photo—hardly any delay as compared to point-and-shoot cameras.

Information and help is available at every step in the menu. Set the D60 to Auto and just about anyone can use it.

The image quality is great—photos turn out crisp and colour reproduction is also pretty good. There is hardly any visible grain with the ISO level set at 100 and 200. The various modes—aperture priority, shutter speed priority and program mode work well. In addition to JPEG, the camera also shoots in RAW, so quality is maintained. Even though the D60 uses a

CCD instead of a CMOS sensor, there is still a significant difference in the quality between a D60 and a P&S.

The D60, like most D-SLRs, is filled to the brim with features. The D60 gives you control over each and every component of the camera. There are also the typical presets for different lighting scenarios to keep things simpler. The interface has been designed to be as simple as on a point-and-shoot. For example, the shutter speed and aperture size are displayed in real life-like illustrations that update in real time when you point it at an object.

The camera runs on SD and SDHC memory cards and it is powered by a Li-ion battery. The flash is fairly powerful. Being a D-SLR, a horse-shoe is available, so you can mount additional flashes to it.

D-SLRs maybe great to learn photography and take professional shots but it isn't something practical for everyday use. Set everything to Auto and you are down to a camera that



behaves like any other P&S. If you want to get into serious photography after having used a P&S for a while, then a beginner D-SLR like a D60 is definitely worth considering. The menus and icons in the camera make it very easy to use, but it will take a while before those used to point-and-shoots are familiar with all of its features.

The D60 kit is priced around Rs 35,950, making it too expensive for a beginner. In terms of specs and performance, there is hardly any difference between a D60 and a D40X—or even a D40, for that matter. We expected something closer to the D80, but it just isn't. In the past few months, the D40X was even selling as low as Rs 27,000. Prices seem to have inflated a bit since

then. Still, D-SLRs selling at reasonable prices are a good sign and there is definitely a slowly growing market for budding photography enthusiasts.

Specifications

10.2 MP CCD Sensor Size: 23.6 x 15.8 mm, Maximum Resolution: 3872x2592, Lens: 18 -55 mm, 2.5-inch 230,000 pixel LCD screen
Dimensions: 126 x 94 x 64 mm, Weight 495 g

Contact: Nikon India Pvt Ltd

Phone: +91-124-4688500

E-mail: nindsupport@nikon.co.in

Web site: www.nikon.com

Price: Rs 35,950

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★